Lesson 3 — The Night the Network Failed

Part 4 of 12: Grammar — the past continuous

Level: A2 (third step)

About 50 minutes · this part carries a sheet

Come back to: the past simple

Lesson 2 taught the form. Three lines to remind you:

REGULAR	WORK → WORKED
Irregular	take → took, keep → kept, go → went
Negative	did not + the plain verb

New this time: the words that put a sentence in the past, and ago.

> yesterday · last night · last week · in March · then · after that · two years ago**

ago counts backwards from now, and it always comes after the length of time, never before: three days ago, not ago three days.

Five more irregular verbs, all of them in today's passage:

NOW	LAST WEEK
write	wrote
buy	bought
sleep	slept
say	said
try	tried (regular)

Quick practice. Put the verb in the past simple:

1. He _____ (buy) a USB drive two days _____.
2. She _____ (write) the report last night.
3. He _____ (sleep) for four hours.
4. His teacher _____ (say) one sentence.

We use the past continuous for an action that was in the middle of happening in the past: At eight o'clock, Omar was uploading his files.

3.1 How we make it

was / were + verb -ing

PERSON	PAST CONTINUOUS
I / he / she / it	was working
you / we / they	were working

3.2 What we use it for

An action in the middle of happening: At eight o'clock he was uploading his files.

A long action stopped by a short one: He was uploading his files when the screen stopped.

Two long actions at the same time: While* the students were laughing, Omar was looking* at his screen.

The background of a story: The room was quiet. Three students were working near the window.

3.4 Past simple or past continuous?

PAST SIMPLE — THE SHORT, FINISHED ACTION	PAST CONTINUOUS — THE LONGER ACTION AROUND IT
The screen stopped.	He was uploading his files.
The lights went out.	The students were working.
The computer turned off.	It was writing to the server.

The rule to remember: when + past simple, while + past continuous.

3.5 Negative and question

	FORM	EXAMPLE
Negative	was not / were not + -ing	Omar was not laughing.
Question	Was / Were + person + -ing	Were the students laughing?

3.6 Grammar practice

A. Put the verb in the past continuous:

1. At eight o'clock, Omar _____ (sit) at his usual desk.
2. Three students _____ (work) near the window.
3. The computer turned off while it _____ (write) to the server.
4. _____ the students _____ (laugh)?
5. Omar _____ (not laugh).

B. Choose the past simple or the past continuous:

1. He (uploaded / was uploading) his files when the screen (stopped / was stopping).
2. While the power (was / was being) off, the students (talked / were talking).

3. He (found / was finding) the email while he (looked / was looking) for the file.